

AUTHOR OR COACH?

A short self-check for how you're actually using AI when you write.

There are two ways to open an AI chat when a character isn't working. You can ask it to write — generate a scene, invent dialogue, spin a backstory. Or you can ask it to ask — question you the way a skilled coach would, until something you already knew arrives on the page in your own words.

Most writers default to the first without noticing they've chosen it. It feels productive. It produces pages. It also means the words on the page came from the tool's statistical average of every scene it has processed, not from the specific thing only you know about this character.

This isn't about whether you should use AI. It's about which of two very different tools you've been reaching for — often without realizing there was a choice.

HOW TO TAKE THIS

Eight questions about habits, not opinions — how you actually behave in a session, not how you'd like to behave. Check whichever option is closer to true right now, based on your last few sessions with AI on your manuscript.

THE SELF-CHECK

1. A scene isn't working. What's the first thing you type into AI?

- ☐ A Something close to "rewrite this scene" or "make this better."
- ☐ B A question about what the character is feeling or hiding in that moment.

2. AI hands you a paragraph of suggested dialogue. What do you usually do?

- ☐ A Take what's useful and drop it into the draft.
- ☐ B Notice it feels generic and start pushing back with a question instead.

3. How does a typical AI session about your character end?

- ☐ A With a finished paragraph or scene you can paste in.
- ☐ B With a sentence you write yourself, in your own words, that you didn't have when you started.

4. AI's first answer to your question doesn't fully satisfy you. What happens next?

- ☐ **A** You move on — it gave you something usable.
- ☐ **B** You ask what's underneath that, or push the same question from a different angle.

5. When you brief AI on a character, what do you typically give it?

- ☐ **A** A general description — "she's tough but caring" — and let it fill in the rest.
- ☐ **B** What you know, what you don't know, and specifically where you're stuck.

6. What was the last thing you actually asked AI to do with a scene?

- ☐ **A** Write it, or a version of it.
- ☐ **B** Ask you a question about it.

7. Picture the AI in the room with you while you write. What's it doing?

- ☐ **A** Typing alongside you, producing pages.
- ☐ **B** Sitting across from you, waiting on your answer.

8. A line of dialogue sounds hollow. What's your instinct?

- ☐ **A** Ask AI to punch it up — sharper words, better rhythm.
 - ☐ **B** Ask AI to ask you what the character isn't saying, and why.
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WHAT YOUR ANSWERS MEAN

Count your A's and B's.

MOSTLY A'S — YOU'RE USING AI AS AN AUTHOR

You're asking AI to produce, and it's fluent at producing — competent scenes, plausible dialogue, technically correct prose. But everything it generates comes from the statistical average of every scene it has processed. It doesn't know your character. It knows the type your character resembles. The words are arriving from the wrong direction — outward, from the tool toward the page — instead of surfacing from what you already carry.

MOSTLY B'S — YOU'RE USING AI AS A COACH

You're treating AI as a Socratic partner — asking it to question you rather than write for you, and refusing its first answer the way you'd refuse your own. What ends up on the page is something only you could have written, retrieved rather than generated. This is considerably harder to sustain than it sounds; most writers drift back toward Author mode without noticing.

A MIX OF BOTH — WHERE MOST WRITERS ACTUALLY LAND

You shift modes depending on how stuck you are, which is normal — Author mode is faster and Coach mode is harder to sustain under deadline pressure. Notice which questions you answered A. Those are the specific moments you're most likely to reach for generation when the harder, better move is a question.

WHAT COACH MODE ACTUALLY SOUNDS LIKE

Whatever you scored, here's a taste of the other mode. A skilled human coach working with you on a character wouldn't ask you to describe them. They'd ask questions like these — and then wait.

- *What hidden cost is this character paying to keep saying these words?*
- *What part of their own history makes the line ring false even to them?*
- *What feeling lingers after they speak — relief, shame, defiance?*
- *Who in the room is this line really aimed at, even if it's spoken to someone else?*
- *What unspoken bargain are they hoping the other person will silently accept by hearing it?*

Try one of these on a scene that isn't working, before you open AI at all. Then bring your answer — not a finished paragraph, just the raw answer — into a session and ask AI to push you past your first response.

IF YOU SCORED MOSTLY A'S

That's not a sign you're using AI wrong. It's the default setting — AI is built to be helpful, and generating a finished answer feels more helpful than asking one more question. Shifting into coach mode on purpose, and staying there when the pull back toward generation gets strong, is a trained skill.

Write Living Characters: A Fiction Writer's Masterclass teaches the Stratum Socratic Writing Method — the exact setup language, briefing structure, and session discipline that keeps AI in coach mode long enough for your own knowledge of your characters to reach the page.